

FARM DATA SHARING AND RESEARCH AGREEMENT

Agreement Version: [Version Number]

Effective Date: [Date]

Project Title: [Research Project Title]

1. Parties

This Farm Data Sharing and Research Agreement (“Agreement”) is entered into between:

Data Provider (“Farmer”):

Name/Farm: [Farmer or Farm Name]

Address: [Address]

Contact: [Email/Phone]

and

Researcher/Research Institution (“Researcher”):

Name: [Researcher Name]

Institution: [University/Organization]

Department/Program: [Department]

Contact: [Email/Phone]

The Farmer and Researcher are collectively referred to as the “Parties.”

2. Purpose

The purpose of this Agreement is to establish the conditions under which the Farmer will provide farm-related data to the Researcher for research purposes.

The Researcher intends to use the data for:

[Describe the research question, project, and intended outcomes.]

The Parties recognize the value of responsible agricultural data sharing while protecting the Farmer's privacy, confidentiality, commercial interests, and control over identifiable farm information.

The Researcher will manage research data in a manner consistent with the **FAIR Data Principles: Findable, Accessible, Interoperable, and Reusable**, subject to the privacy, confidentiality, security, and use restrictions established by this Agreement.

3. Data Covered by This Agreement

The Farmer agrees to provide the following data:

- [Animal production data]
- [Milk production and/or milk quality data]
- [Animal health and veterinary data]
- [Reproductive data]
- [Feed and nutrition data]
- [Housing and management data]
- [Environmental or weather data]
- [Crop/soil data]
- [Financial or economic data, if applicable]
- [Farm management software records]
- [Sensor, wearable, or automated monitoring data]
- [Other: _____]

Data collection period: [Dates]

Method of transfer: [Secure file transfer/encrypted storage/API/etc.]

Only data reasonably necessary to accomplish the stated research purpose should be collected.

4. Data Ownership and Control

Unless otherwise agreed in writing, the Farmer retains ownership of the original farm data provided under this Agreement.

Providing data to the Researcher does **not** transfer ownership of the Farmer's original data.

The Farmer grants the Researcher a:

- ☐ Non-exclusive
- ☐ Royalty-free
- ☐ Non-transferable, except as permitted under this Agreement

license to use the data solely for the research purposes described in this Agreement.

The Researcher may create analyses, statistical models, aggregated datasets, research findings, and other research outputs derived from the data. Ownership and permitted use of these outputs will be governed by this Agreement and applicable institutional policies.

5. Permitted Uses

The Researcher may use the Farmer's data for:

- Conducting the research described in Section 2.
- Statistical and computational analysis.
- Creating aggregated or appropriately de-identified research datasets.
- Developing research publications, theses, presentations, reports, and educational materials.
- Validating or reproducing research findings, subject to the confidentiality provisions of this Agreement.
- Other uses specifically approved in writing by the Farmer.

The Researcher will not use the data for unrelated commercial purposes, farm benchmarking that publicly identifies the Farmer, regulatory enforcement, marketing, sale to third parties, or other purposes outside the scope of this Agreement without additional written authorization.

6. FAIR Data Principles

The Parties acknowledge that FAIR does **not** necessarily mean that data must be publicly available. FAIR practices will be implemented subject to the confidentiality and access restrictions in this Agreement.

6.1 Findable

Where appropriate, research datasets and outputs will be assigned:

- Clear and descriptive titles.
- Persistent identifiers, such as DOIs, where appropriate.
- Sufficient metadata to describe the data and its origin.
- Version information and dates.
- Documentation allowing authorized researchers to identify relevant datasets.

Public metadata should not identify an individual Farmer or farm unless the Farmer has explicitly consented to identification.

6.2 Accessible

Access to data will be governed by clearly defined conditions.

Raw identifiable farm data will:

- Be accessible only to authorized personnel.
- Be stored using appropriate security safeguards.
- Not be made publicly accessible without the Farmer's explicit written permission.

Where research data are shared with other researchers, access may be provided through:

- ☐ Public repository for fully anonymized/aggregated data
- ☐ Controlled-access repository
- ☐ Data-use agreement
- ☐ Case-by-case approval
- ☐ Other: _____

Metadata may remain available even when access to the underlying dataset is restricted.

6.3 Interoperable

When practical, the Researcher will:

- Use non-proprietary or widely adopted file formats.
- Apply consistent variable names, units, and definitions.
- Use recognized agricultural, veterinary, or scientific terminology and standards when available.
- Maintain a data dictionary describing variables, units, codes, missing values, and transformations.
- Document software, equipment, or collection systems necessary to interpret the data.

These practices are intended to facilitate integration of the research data with other appropriate datasets without compromising confidentiality.

6.4 Reusable

To support appropriate reuse, the Researcher will maintain documentation describing:

- Data provenance and source.
- Collection methods.
- Data cleaning and processing.
- Relevant farm management context when necessary for interpretation.
- Variable definitions.
- Units of measurement.
- Known limitations.
- Quality-control procedures.
- Conditions governing reuse.

Reuse by researchers outside the original project will be permitted only under the access and confidentiality conditions established by this Agreement.

7. Privacy, Confidentiality, and De-identification

The Researcher will make reasonable efforts to protect the identity of the Farmer, farm, employees, clients, and other individuals represented in the data.

When appropriate, direct identifiers will be removed or replaced with coded identifiers.

Potential identifiers include:

- Farmer or owner names.
- Farm names.

- Exact addresses.
- Telephone numbers and email addresses.
- GPS coordinates or highly precise location information.
- Animal or herd identifiers that could reasonably be linked to the farm.
- Employee information.
- Financial account information.
- Other information that could reasonably identify the Farmer or farm.

The Researcher will not identify the Farmer or farm in publications or presentations without explicit permission.

Identification preference:

- ☐ Farmer/farm must remain anonymous.
 - ☐ Farmer/farm may be acknowledged with written approval before publication.
 - ☐ Farmer/farm may be publicly identified.
 - ☐ Other: _____
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8. Data Security

The Researcher will implement reasonable administrative, technical, and physical safeguards, which may include:

- Password-protected accounts.
- Encryption during transfer and storage.
- Access controls.
- Secure institutional storage.
- Regular backups.
- Access logs where appropriate.
- Limiting access to authorized research personnel.

Authorized personnel:

[Identify researchers, research teams, or categories of personnel.]

Any authorized individual receiving access to identifiable or confidential data must comply with the confidentiality requirements of this Agreement.

9. Data Sharing With Third Parties

The Researcher may not provide identifiable farm data to third parties except:

1. With the Farmer's written permission;
2. To authorized members of the research team bound by appropriate confidentiality requirements; or
3. When required by law, regulation, court order, or institutional obligation.

For FAIR-compliant research sharing, appropriately de-identified or aggregated data may be made available under the following conditions:

[Describe repository, access restrictions, data-use agreement, licensing terms, etc.]

Third parties receiving controlled-access data must agree to applicable restrictions, including restrictions against attempting to re-identify participating farms.

10. Publications and Research Outputs

The Researcher may publish results derived from the data in scientific journals, theses, conference presentations, reports, and other scholarly outputs provided that the outputs comply with this Agreement.

Results should normally be reported in aggregated or de-identified form.

Before publication:

- ☐ No Farmer review is required if the results are fully de-identified.
- ☐ Farmer will receive a copy for review of confidential information only.
- ☐ Farmer approval is required before identifiable information is published.
- ☐ Other: _____

Farmer review, when applicable, is intended to protect confidential or identifying information and not to improperly restrict legitimate scientific findings.

11. Intellectual Property and Commercialization

The Parties acknowledge that research involving farm data may produce new methods, algorithms, software, inventions, or other intellectual property.

The following terms will apply:

[Describe institutional IP policy and/or negotiated terms.]

The Researcher will not sell or license identifiable Farmer data as a standalone commercial product without separate written authorization.

12. Data Quality and Farmer Responsibilities

The Farmer agrees to provide data in good faith but does not guarantee that the data are complete, error-free, or suitable for a particular research purpose.

The Researcher is responsible for evaluating data quality and documenting relevant limitations.

The Researcher will not knowingly misrepresent the Farmer's data, farming practices, or research findings.

13. Data Retention and Destruction

Research data will be retained for:

[Number] years after [project completion/publication/etc.], or as otherwise required by institutional, funding, journal, or legal requirements.

At the end of the retention period:

- ☐ Identifiable data will be securely destroyed.
- ☐ Data will be permanently de-identified and retained.
- ☐ Data will be transferred to a controlled-access archive.
- ☐ Other: _____

Metadata necessary to document published research may be retained when appropriate.

14. Withdrawal

The Farmer may request to stop providing additional data by contacting:

[Researcher/contact information]

Upon withdrawal:

- No additional data will be collected from the Farmer unless otherwise agreed.
- Identifiable data not yet incorporated into completed analyses may be deleted where reasonably possible.
- Data already incorporated into completed analyses, aggregated datasets, publications, or legally required research records may not be capable of being withdrawn.
- Previously shared anonymized data may not be retrievable if they can no longer reasonably be linked to the Farmer.

The Researcher will clearly explain any limitations on withdrawal.

15. Data Breach or Unauthorized Access

If the Researcher becomes aware of unauthorized access, disclosure, loss, or misuse of identifiable Farmer data, the Researcher will follow applicable institutional and legal incident-response requirements.

Where appropriate or required, the Farmer will be informed of:

- The nature of the incident.
 - The data potentially affected.
 - Actions taken to contain the incident.
 - Reasonable steps the Farmer may take in response.
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16. Benefits, Risks, and Compensation

Potential Benefits

Possible benefits may include improved understanding of agricultural production, animal health, farm management, sustainability, economics, or other outcomes relevant to the research project.

Participation does not guarantee a direct benefit to the Farmer.

Potential Risks

Potential risks include inadvertent disclosure of confidential farm information, re-identification, reputational harm, or unauthorized use of data. The safeguards described in this Agreement are intended to minimize these risks.

Compensation

- ☐ No compensation will be provided.
 - ☐ Farmer will receive: [Compensation]
 - ☐ Other arrangement: _____
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17. Research Results Returned to Farmer

The Farmer will receive:

- ☐ Summary of overall study findings
- ☐ Farm-specific results
- ☐ Benchmarking results using de-identified comparison data
- ☐ Copies of resulting publications
- ☐ No individual research results
- ☐ Other: _____

Farm-specific research results should be interpreted within the limitations of the study and should not automatically be considered veterinary, financial, legal, or management advice.

18. Compliance and Ethical Oversight

The Researcher will conduct the research in accordance with applicable laws, regulations, institutional policies, funding requirements, and research ethics requirements.

Where applicable:

Institutional Review Board (IRB): [Protocol/Status]

Institutional Animal Care and Use Committee (IACUC): [Protocol/Status]

Other approval: [Specify]

19. Changes to This Agreement

Material changes to the permitted uses, sharing conditions, confidentiality provisions, or scope of data collection must be documented in writing and agreed to by the Parties when required under this Agreement.

20. Term and Termination

This Agreement begins on [Date] and continues until [Date/Event].

Either Party may terminate participation by providing [number] days' written notice, subject to the provisions governing data already used, analyzed, or shared.

21. Governing Law and Institutional Requirements

This Agreement will be governed by:

[State/Jurisdiction and applicable institutional policies.]

If this template is used through a university or other research institution, the institution's authorized research, contracting, privacy, or legal office should review the Agreement before execution.

22. Contact Information

Questions concerning the research or use of farm data may be directed to:

Principal Researcher:

Name: [Name]

Institution: [Institution]

Email: [Email]

Phone: [Phone]

Data/Privacy Contact:

Name/Office: [Name or Office]

Email: [Email]

Phone: [Phone]

SIGNATURES

By signing below, the Parties acknowledge that they have reviewed and agree to the terms of this Farm Data Sharing and Research Agreement.

Farmer / Data Provider

Name: _____

Farm: _____

Signature: _____

Date: _____

Researcher

Name: _____

Title: _____

Institution: _____

Signature: _____

Date: _____

Institutional Representative, if required

Name: _____

Title: _____

Signature: _____

Date: _____

APPENDIX A — DATA INVENTORY

Dataset/Data Type	Source	Date Range	Identifiable?	Access Level	Retention Period
[Example: Milk production]	[Dairy software]	[Dates]	[Yes/No]	[Restricted]	[Years]

APPENDIX B — FAIR DATA MANAGEMENT PLAN

Findable

Repository/location: []

Metadata standard: []

Persistent identifier: [_____]

Accessible

Access level: [Public/Controlled/Restricted]

Access procedure: []

Authorized users: []

Interoperable

File formats: [CSV/JSON/etc.]

Terminology/ontology standards: []

Data dictionary location: []

Reusable

License/data-use conditions: []

Required citation: []

Provenance documentation: []

Reuse restrictions: []

APPENDIX C — OPTIONAL DATA USE PERMISSIONS

The Farmer may separately authorize the following:

- ☐ Use in the research project described in this Agreement.
- ☐ Use in closely related future research.
- ☐ Use in unrelated agricultural research after de-identification.
- ☐ Deposit of de-identified data in a controlled research repository.
- ☐ Public release of fully anonymized/aggregated data.
- ☐ Sharing with research collaborators under equivalent data protections.
- ☐ Commercial research or product development.
- ☐ Use for development or training of machine-learning/AI systems.

Additional restrictions or permissions:
